

black and 305 for colour), but its black and colour cartridges cost around Rs 2,000, which push its cost per page to Rs 8.20.

Warranty and support

Printers suffer a lot of wear and tear due to heat build up as they are thermal devices, and there is constant friction within all the moving parts. It is not uncommon to face frequent paper jams, ink leaks and misalignment after about a year of regular use. Hence, a printer should be at least under a repair warranty for more than two years, ideally for three years.

Not one manufacturer provided such a warranty. Providing a large service network and support across cities helps to a certain extent but lack of a repair warranty extended beyond a year is hard to justify.

HP has the largest service network in this country—it claims to have over 230 service centres across 79 Indian cities. It provides a carry-in warranty on its printers and the best thing is that a printer will be replaced or repaired within 48 hours. With such a wide network you generally wouldn't face a problem getting your printer to a service centre.

What it all leads to...

After putting the printers through the battery of tests for performance, features and economy, the following are the ones that emerged victorious:

Budget printers: This category is where most home users will make their purchases from. A budget printer does not necessarily mean low performance. As a matter of fact, the **Lexmark Z25** gives the mid-range printers a run for their

money and is our Best Performance winner. This printer is a powerhouse when it comes to text printing speed but it compromises on quality a fair bit. However, it does pretty well in the colour photo quality test. The Lexmark Z35 too is a good printer and it was beaten by a hair's breadth here. The Lexmark Z25 should top your list if you want the best colour photo quality combined with blazing text printing speeds.

The **Lexmark Z13** wins our Best Value Award. This printer costs just Rs 2,990 and offers acceptable print quality. Though the cost per page is Rs 8.80, if you are in the market for a printer that has a low initial cost, and you need only occasional printouts, then the Lexmark Z13 should be your choice.

Mid-range printers: It would be difficult for most printers to match the print quality of the **HP Deskjet 920C**. It can print amazing photo prints and it wins our Best Performance Award hands down. All through the test this printer kept plugging away at the scores: it came in second in the text printing quality test and in the combi document test. But what clinches the deal is the fact that it is the best printer in its category as far as photo printing goes.

The Best Value Award in this segment goes indisputably to the **HP Deskjet 845C**. It offers high quality printing at a decent price—it costs just Rs 6,499! Couple this with a relatively low cost per page of Rs 5.10 and you have a winner on your hands.

High-end printers: Compare a photo printout of the **HP Deskjet 970CXi** to a real photograph and you'll probably end up searching for flaws in the photograph itself. Vibrant rendering of colours and unmatched quality of text printout makes this the champion in the high-end arena. It bagged the Best



Caring for Your Printer

- Align the ink cartridge after you've installed it. Use the software bundled with the printer for doing this.
- Always store cartridges in their factory-supplied containers or in a small, zip-lock bag in a cool and dry place.
- To avoid paper jams, clean the inside rollers with alcohol. Set your paper guides carefully when placing paper in the in-tray. Never mix paper types in the same tray. Fan through the sheets to separate them before loading the paper tray.
- Use the paper recommended by your printer manufacturer. Use good quality

paper even for printing drafts as it prevents paper dust from clogging the printer.

- Always use your printer's power switch rather than the switch on a surge protector to switch off your printer.
- Over a period of time, the prints you get will become faint and there will be lines running across the page. To restore the original print quality, many inkjets come with a nozzle clearing function that blows ink through the nozzles to unclog them. Use this feature regularly, especially if the printer has been unused for weeks.

- If you find a leak, don't try to fix it yourself. Call the authorised service centre.
- For optimum and trouble-free performance, always use the original ink cartridges and do not get them refilled.
- Air bubbles in the cartridge can cause your printer to shut down. Never shake your ink cartridge as that creates bubbles.
- If you remove a part of your ink system such as the print head or ink reservoir, remember to replace it. Opening the system for even a few hours allows the ink to dry out and clog the print head.

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